

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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WSJ.com

★★★★ \$5.00

DJIA 48996.08 ▼ 466.00 0.94%

NASDAQ 23584.27 ▲ 0.2%

STOXX 600 604.99 ▼ 0.05%

10-YR. TREAS. ▲ 11/32, yield 4.137%

OIL \$55.99 ▼ \$1.14

GOLD \$4,449.30 ▼ \$32.90

EURO \$1.1676

YEN 156.77

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Warner Bros. Discovery** recommended its shareholders reject Paramount's amended hostile bid for the company, saying its existing deal with Netflix is stronger. **B1**

◆ **World Liberty Financial**, the Trump family's flagship crypto venture, said that one of its entities has applied for a national banking license. **A2**

◆ **JPMorgan Chase's** asset-management unit cut all ties with proxy-advisory firms and will start using AI to assist on U.S. company votes. **B1**

◆ **JPMorgan** reached an agreement to take over the Apple credit-card program from Goldman Sachs. **B2**

◆ **Anthropic** plans to raise \$10 billion at a valuation of \$350 billion before the new investment, nearly doubling its valuation from four months ago. **B1**

◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** ended mixed, with the S&P 500 and Dow falling 0.3% and 0.9%, respectively, while the Nasdaq rose 0.2%. **B9**

◆ **AbbVie** is in advanced talks to buy cancer-drug biotech Revolution Medicines in what would be one of the year's first megadeals. **B1**

◆ **The private sector** added a net 41,000 new employees last month, after shedding 29,000 jobs in November, ADP estimated in its latest report. **A2**

◆ **Media startup Semafor** raised \$30 million in new financing that values the company at \$330 million after its first profitable year. **B4**

◆ **Samsung** expects record above-consensus earnings for its latest quarter, boosted by an AI-driven memory-chip supercycle that is fueling demand for its products. **B4**

Worldwide

◆ **Trump and his advisers** are planning a sweeping initiative to dominate the Venezuelan oil industry for years to come and the president has told aides he believes his efforts could help lower oil prices to his favored level of \$50 a barrel. **A1**

◆ **The U.S. military** forcibly boarded a ship being escorted by the Russian navy and seized another tanker, accelerating its campaign against a shadow fleet of carriers that ship Venezuelan oil. **A1**

◆ **Secretary of State Marco Rubio** said he would meet with Danish and Greenlandic officials after the Danes requested a sitdown in hope of addressing criticism directed at them by the Trump administration. **A6**

◆ **An AI startup** and Google agreed to settle several lawsuits with families of teenagers who killed or harmed themselves after interacting with the startup's chatbot. **A4**

◆ **Rep. Steny Hoyer** of Maryland, a longtime member of House Democratic leadership, won't run for re-election. **A4**

◆ **Trump administration** officials made sweeping changes to federal dietary guidelines, recommending that people avoid highly processed foods, dramatically increase protein intake and skip added sugar. **A1**

◆ **Trump said he is** taking steps to ban large investors from buying single-family homes. **A3**

◆ **The CBO** further trimmed its long-term forecast for U.S. population growth. **A3**

◆ **Florida Gov. DeSantis** said he would call a special session for the GOP-dominated legislature to draw new congressional districts. **A4**

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Minneapolis on Edge After Fatal ICE Shooting



STEPHEN MATUREN/GETTY IMAGES

DIVIDED: Authorities investigated Wednesday after an ICE officer shot to death a woman in her car during a confrontation with agents in Minneapolis. City and federal officials offered starkly different narratives about what led to the killing. **A3**

U.S. Seizes Two More Tankers, Adding to Pressure on Caracas

The U.S. military forcibly boarded a ship being escorted by the Russian navy and seized another tanker on

By Shelby Holliday, Costas Paris and Lara Seligman

Wednesday, accelerating its campaign against a shadow fleet of tankers that ship Venezuelan oil.

The confiscation of the two tankers extended an extraordinary string of actions on the

high seas by U.S. Defense Department and Coast Guard personnel, which are targeting vessels around Venezuela that the administration says are engaging in deceptive practices and carrying illicit oil shipments. Four vessels are now in U.S. custody, and the quasi-embargo in the Caribbean has crippled Venezuelan oil exports.

The Justice Department is monitoring several more tankers for similar enforcement action, Attorney General Pam

Bondi posted on X.

The seizures mark another escalation in President Trump's pledge to take control of the Venezuelan oil industry, coming in the days after the U.S. deposed the country's leader Nicolás Maduro and said Venezuela would give the U.S. 30 million to 50 million barrels of oil—as much as 15% of the country's output. One broker estimated the value at between \$1.5 billion and \$2.5 billion.

Early on Wednesday, a special-operations force boarded a

ship called the *Marinera*, a tanker formerly known as the *Bella 1*. The Coast Guard had been pursuing the vessel for two weeks on an odyssey that began near Venezuela and ended south of Iceland, U.S. officials said. Over that time, the ship—which wasn't carrying any oil—changed its name and claimed Russian protection.

Adding to the stakes: A Russian navy ship and submarine began escorting the tanker, the officials said. The submarine

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Trump Doctrine Confounds Allies, Foes

By YAROSLAV TROFIMOV

President Trump's new "Donroe Doctrine"—loudly proclaimed by the seizure of Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro and the president's assertion that Washington now "runs" the Latin American country—seeks to establish U.S. hegemony over the entire

Western Hemisphere.

The question U.S. adversaries and allies are asking themselves in the aftermath of the Caracas raid is whether this embrace of 19th-century-style imperial thinking also means a pivot away from the rest of the world that would give China and Russia greater sway in their neighborhoods.

"It's not a world dominance that Trump is trying to achieve, but a hemispheric dominance," German lawmaker Norbert Röttgen said. "His worldview seems to be thinking in categories of spheres of influence—and dominance by those in other hemispheres who are the most powerful there, irrespective of

rules, laws and alliances."

Buoyed by the success of the Jan. 3 operation in Venezuela, Trump has signaled potential U.S. intervention in Cuba, Colombia, Mexico, the Danish possession of Greenland—and, out

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◆ **Talks over Greenland** are planned..... **A6**

Trump Works to Dominate Venezuela Oil Sector

Plan seeks control of most of hemisphere's crude, aims to lower prices to \$50 a barrel

President Trump and his advisers are planning a sweeping initiative to dominate the Venezuelan oil industry for years to come and the president has told aides he believes his efforts could help lower oil prices to his favored level of \$50 a barrel, according to people familiar with the matter.

By Brian Schwartz, Benoit Morenne and Josh Dawsey

A plan under consideration envisions the U.S. exerting some control over Venezuela's state-run oil company *Petróleos de Venezuela SA*, or *PdVSA*, including acquiring and marketing the bulk of the company's oil production, people familiar with the matter said.

If successful, the plan could effectively give the U.S. stewardship of most of the oil reserves in the Western Hemisphere, when factoring deposits in the U.S. and other countries where American companies control production. It could also fulfill two of the administration's primary goals: to box Russia and China out of Venezuela and to push energy prices lower for U.S. consumers.

Trump has repeatedly raised the prospect of lowering oil prices to \$50 a barrel, his preferred level, two senior administration officials said.

But oil prices are already low, with the U.S. benchmark hovering around \$56 a barrel Wednesday, and Trump has struggled to convince U.S. oil-and-gas producers to crank out more crude and help him accomplish his political goals. Many companies see \$50 a barrel as a threshold below which it becomes unprofitable to drill,

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◆ **Maduro's enforcer** stands in Trump's way..... **A7**

◆ **Rubio, MAGA convert**, takes reins on Venezuela..... **A7**

New Diet Guidelines: Eat More Protein, Less Sugar

Trump administration officials made sweeping changes to U.S. dietary guidelines, recommending that people avoid highly processed foods, dramatically increase protein intake and skip added sugar.

By Jesse Newman, Liz Essley Whyte and Andrea Petersen

The new guidelines issued Wednesday urge people to cook more meals at home, avoid packaged food like chips, cookies and candy—and eat protein at every meal. They echo the government's previous advice that fruits, vegetables, whole grains, poultry, seafood and nuts form the basis of a healthy diet.

But they also endorse foods like red meat and full-fat dairy, while taking a hard line against highly processed foods, added sugar and refined carbohydrates like white bread.

The recommendations, issued by the U.S. Agriculture and Health and Human Services departments, represent one of the biggest remakes of federal dietary advice since the guidelines were first is-

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INSIDE



PERSONAL JOURNAL

The highs, lows and hidden costs of taking the kids to a Great Wolf Lodge water park. **A10**



SPORTS

In college football, Miami's two-headed sack machine shuts down foes. **A16**

Skateboarders Beg San Francisco To Save Its Biggest Eyesore

Critics call it a 'jumble of nothing.'

To skaters, Vaillancourt Fountain is Mecca.

By ROBERT MCMILLAN

Skateboarders are trying to pull off their gnarliest trick: saving San Francisco's most hated monument from extinction.

The city wants to take down Vaillancourt Fountain. Skaters say the structure—brutalist water-pumping limbs of mottled white concrete that rise out of the ground near the waterfront—is an icon.

Skateboarders worldwide know the area as EMB, shorthand for Embarcadero Plaza.

It's where, in the early 1990s, the activity evolved out of skate parks and empty pools into a global urban phenomenon that could be done nearly anywhere there were benches, stairs and railings.

"That's Mecca," said Ted Barrow, a skateboarder and architectural preservationist who has defended the fountain at public hearings. "The most important videos were filmed there. People come here just to see it because they feel like they're on hal-

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How Google Got Its AI Groove Back

Powerful new Gemini model allowed it to catch up to OpenAI's ChatGPT

By KATHERINE BLUNT

In the wee hours of an August morning, an artificial-intelligence project manager at Google loaded the newest creation from its DeepMind lab onto a platform that ranks AI models.

Google had fallen behind in the AI race, while its rival OpenAI had attracted hundreds of millions of users to its ChatGPT chatbot. Google researchers were hoping that

a new feature—a lightning-fast image generator—would give the search titan an edge in a weak spot for ChatGPT.

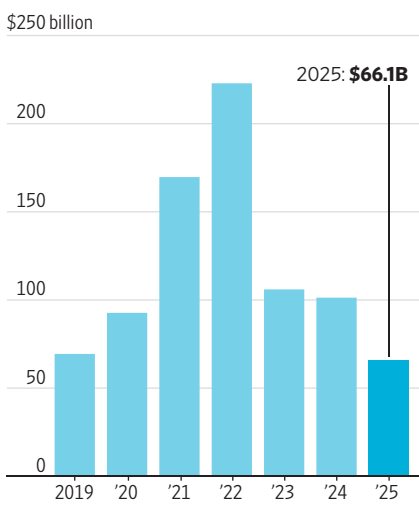
Naina Raisinghani, known inside Google for working late into the night, needed a name for the new tool to complete the upload. It was 2:30 a.m., though, and nobody was around. So she just made one up, a mashup of two nicknames friends had given her: Nano Banana.

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VC Funds Feel IPO Drought

Fundraising for U.S. venture-capital firms dropped 35% in 2025, the most anemic stretch in at least six years. Startups that have been flush with venture funding have opted to remain private, rather than exposing themselves to public market scrutiny. **B1**

U.S. venture capital raised, annually



Source: PitchBook